



into a wide ridge of **mountains** known as the highlands, a territory that is so densely forested that the island's local peoples remained **isolated** from each other for thousands of years. As a result, incredibly,

there are as many as **800** different languages in Papua New Guinea. One of the many peoples that live in the Highlands are the extraordinary Huli, famous for their spectacular **head adornments**.

Huli wig school

One interesting feature about the Huli people is their elaborate wigs. As teenagers, the boys are taken from their homes to live in and attend wig school for several years. They learn to be efficient warriors and good community members but, most importantly, they grow and tend to their hair, which will one day be cut and made into spectacular wigs.

The students at wig school put cassowary wing feathers through their noses.



WIG CARE

It is essential to look after the growing hair in order to keep it in prime condition. Without magical rites, the instruction of a hair trainer, and constant grooming, men cannot grow their hair sufficiently to satisfy traditional wig requirements. They even sleep with their heads propped up to keep from flattening the shape.



THE FINISHED WIG

When the hair is considered long enough it is cut and, while still keeping the mushroom shape, it is decorated with bright feathers, daisies, and even possum fur.



SING-SING

The ceremonial wigs are worn during *sing-sings*—ceremonies that include initiation rites and weddings. Neighbors are sometimes invited to attend *sing-sings* and clans and families have a chance to show solidarity and exhibit wealth. They perform dances in their groups and feast on pigs.

These men are painting their faces—using car sideview mirrors to aid them! A small sign of modern influence.

